

# Riverbed, Shrine Gate and Hillside: Higashiyama and the Kamo River

Between the Kamo River and the Higashiyama hills lies ground that was once open riverbed, shrine land and the road to a burial field. Embankments turned it into Gion's teahouse streets, a flood in 1935 remade the river, and war erased one street while sparing the rest. This dossier shows how to read those layers today.



東山・鴨川（京都市東山区）

## In this dossier

1. A history of the district (7 chapters, about 2200 words)
2. Timeline
3. Walking notes, walk map and photographs of the stops
4. Then and now: aerial photographs
5. How the ground was made
6. Disasters remembered
7. Sources (23) and further reading

Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

## A river the emperors could not command

The Kamo River rises in the mountains north of Kyoto, enters the basin at Kamigamo, meets the Takano River near Demachi and runs for about 23 km down the eastern side of the city, picking up the Shirakawa stream near Shijo before it joins the Katsura at Shimotoba. A prefectural gazetteer of 1915 describes a bed of sand and gravel carrying shallow, clear water against the green screen of the Higashiyama hills. What no one could tame was the flood. The Tale of the Heike has the retired emperor Shirakawa name the waters of the Kamo first among the three things he could not control, ahead of the dice of the sugoroku board and the warrior monks of Mount Hiei.<sup>25</sup>

The court set up an office to guard against the river, the Bokashi (防鴨河使), in 824, but Kyoto City's historians judge that it achieved little: in a flood of 1017 the city east of Tominokoji became a sea and about 300 patients of the Hiden-in charity hospital were swept away. Until the seventeenth century the Kamo was a natural river with wide flats of stones on either bank. In 1669 work began on new stone embankments, finished the following year. This Kanbun embankment (寛文新堤) fixed the channel, the flats behind it were built over, and the riverside townscape that visitors now take for granted was born.<sup>5</sup>

## Shrine land and the road to Kiyomizu

East of the river the ground rises through the precinct of the Gion shrine, called Gion-sha or Gion Kanshin-in until 1868 and Yasaka Shrine since. The shrine keeps two founding traditions: that in 656 a man named Irishi, who had come from Koma (the Korean kingdom of Goguryeo), enshrined here Susanoo, the god of Mount Gozu in Silla; and that the Nara monk Ennyo built a hall on the spot in 876. A government decree of 1070 in the shrine's archives set its domain as the land between the hills and the Kamo, from Sanjo south to old Gojo, today's Matsubara-dori, which is roughly the northern half of the area covered by this dossier. By the shrine's account the Gion festival began in 869, when an epidemic was answered with 66 halberds, one for each province, and the shrine's portable shrine was carried to the imperial garden of Shinsen-en.<sup>315</sup>

South of the shrine the district was a threshold. Rokuhara, between old Gojo and Shichijo, was the way into Toribeno, the burial ground on the slopes, and was imagined as the border between this world and the next. Kuya founded the temple that became Rokuharamitsuji in 963; in the twelfth century the Taira clan filled Rokuhara with their mansions, and burned them when they fled the capital in 1183. The same lanes were the pilgrim road to Kiyomizu-dera, which a late-Heian song collection maps stop by stop from the stone bridge at Gojo. Kiyomizu-dera dates its founding to 778, beside the spring that still falls as the Otowa waterfall; most of its present halls, including the main hall with its famous stage over the slope, were rebuilt in 1633.<sup>616</sup>

Toyotomi Hideyoshi reshaped the southern half. From 1586 he raised a Great Buddha hall about 49 m high just south of today's Gojo-dori; its precinct took in the present Hokoji, Toyokuni Shrine and Kyoto National Museum, whose west side still shows the colossal stone walls. The gazetteer of 1915 records that in the Tensho era he moved the Gojo bridge south from Matsubara to its present line, so that the street now called Gojo runs where the old Rokujo-bomon lane ran. In 1597 a mound, which today stands west of Toyokuni Shrine, was raised to bury the noses and ears cut from Korean soldiers and civilians during his invasions of Korea and brought back as trophies; first called the nose mound, it is known as Mimizuka (耳塚). The bell whose inscription Tokugawa Ieyasu used in 1614 as a pretext for the war that destroyed the Toyotomi still hangs at Hokoji.<sup>27</sup>

## From riverbed to pleasure quarter

A city guide of 1928 describes the land between Shijo bridge and the Gion shrine, after the medieval wars, as a poor hamlet of scattered farmhouses. From the early Edo period, through the seventeenth century and into the eighteenth, its fields were laid out as streets; tea stalls opened for pilgrims to Gion and Kiyomizu, and in time became restaurants and houses of entertainment. Kyoto City's preservation plan for Gion Shinbashi ties that growth to the Kamo embankment, which pushed the

city east across the river, and dates the teahouse streets of Gion's 'inner six blocks' to 1712. According to the 1915 gazetteer, residents won licenses for thirty teahouses in 1732 in return for paying to rebuild the Yamato bridge, which it treats as the beginning of Gion's licensed quarter.<sup>2412</sup>

The theater came first. Kabuki began, the 1928 guide says, with performances beside the south gate of the Gion shrine that moved on to the Shijo riverbed. The gazetteer records that seven licensed theaters were permitted on Shijo in 1669, the same year the embankment work began; by the Meiji Restoration two were left, and when the northern one burned the Minamiza (南座) remained alone. West of the river, the merchant Suminokura Ryoï and his son opened the Takase canal in 1614, carrying firewood, rice and sake from Fushimi in flat-bottomed boats about 13 m long until the canal closed in 1920.<sup>248</sup>

The hillside developed its own trades. Kyoto City's plan for Sannenzaka describes a gate town for Kiyomizu-dera, Hoka-ji (the Yasaka pagoda) and the Gion shrine, whose houses spread from the mid-Edo period along the paths linking the temples; its tea shops and craft stores continue the business of early-modern sightseeing. The 1928 guide offers two stories for the slope's name: a hall at Kiyomizu for safe childbirth (産寧, sannei), or a road opened in 808, the third year of Daido. It also notes that Gojo-zaka was lined with pottery shops and the workshops of the best Kiyomizu-ware potters, while Kiyomizu-zaka sold ceramic dolls and sake cups to visitors from the provinces.<sup>413</sup>

## Iron bridges, a canal and a railway

In 1868 the new government's separation of Shinto and Buddhism turned Gion-sha into Yasaka Shrine. Its Buddhist images went to nearby temples and Buddhist names were removed, although the old name Kanshin-in is still cut into the stone basin just inside the west gate. The pleasure quarter, by then in decline, reinvented itself: for the Kyoto Exhibition of 1872 the owner of the Ichiriki teahouse and the dance teachers devised a new dance, first staged that March in a borrowed hall, and in 1873 it moved to a new dance hall built on Hanamikoji under the name Miyako Odori. By 1915 the gazetteer could report that the dance was known in Europe and America as the 'Cherry Dance'.<sup>23415</sup>

The bridges modernised first. Residents of the ward paid for an iron Shijo bridge in April 1874; when the city laid tram tracks it was rebuilt as five reinforced-concrete arches, four over the Kamo and one over the canal, in works completed in 1913. The Lake Biwa Canal reached Kyoto in 1890 and its Kamo extension, running down the east bank to Fushimi through eight locks, was finished in 1894. From 1910 the Keihan railway from Osaka ended at Gojo, and in 1915 it was extended to Sanjo, squeezed between the canal and the river. The 1915 gazetteer judged that the Kamo, once the scourge of the capital, now rarely harmed the city because 'flood control is in place'.<sup>25117</sup>

## The morning of 29 June 1935

Twenty years later the river answered. A pamphlet published by Kyoto Prefecture in 1935 records four bursts of rain of about 40 mm an hour between 11 p.m. on 28 June and 8 a.m. the next morning; the Kyoto observatory measured 269.9 mm for the day, far above the previous record of 161.3 mm set on 20 August 1900. By 5 a.m. houses around Shijo bridge stood in a meter of water and by 7.30 a.m. in 1.5 m. Driftwood jammed under the Shijo and Shichijo bridges, and in Pontocho and Shichijo Sannocho the water rose more than 2 m above the floors. Soldiers, firemen and youth groups worked through the night to hold the Kamo embankment upstream; had it broken, the pamphlet says, almost the whole city would have become a sea of mud.<sup>1</sup>

Of fifty bridges over the Kamo and Takano inside the city, 35 road bridges and one railway bridge fell, the Sanjo and Gojo bridges among them; only ten came through undamaged, and the mud took more than a month to clear. Kyoto Prefecture's figures today for the Kamo alone are 12 dead or injured, 137 houses washed away and 24,173 flooded; counting the other rivers, 83 people were killed or injured across the city. The Keihan terminus at Sanjo, caught between the canal and the torrent, was badly damaged.<sup>1911</sup>

The pamphlet set out a remedy: widen the channel to about 70 m, dig the bed 1 to 3 m deeper to pass 650 cubic meters a second at Shijo, rebuild the banks in stone, and put the Keihan tracks underground beneath the canal with a road on top, removing what it called a 'cancer' on the city's growth. The prefecture carried out the river works from 1936 to 1947, lowering

the bed by about 2 m on average, and reports that they brought the Kamo to a standard that carried the flood of August 1959, whose rainfall exceeded that of 1935, without flooding the city. The railway half of the plan had to wait half a century.<sup>1910</sup>

## War: a spared city and an erased street

Kyoto is often said to have escaped the war; a 2014 study of its wartime demolitions calls it a 'non-war-damaged city'. It was not untouched. On the night of 16 January 1945 American bombs fell on Umamachi in Higashiyama, killing more than thirty people. It was Kyoto's first air raid, and with the Nishijin raid of 26 June it is how the city remembers its war. The poet Yoshii Isamu, living two kilometers to the north, noted in his diary that he was told the bombs had fallen 'at Gojo-zaka', that there had been nine of them and about thirty dead, and a few days later that many people in Higashiyama were leaving.<sup>20 21</sup>

The greater loss was planned. Although Kyoto was not designated an evacuation zone, from 1944 it demolished houses for firebreaks in four rounds. The third, in March and April 1945, cleared belts along Horikawa, Oike and Gojo and around Kyoto Station: 140 sites, 120 hectares and 10,475 houses, according to a 2007 historical atlas summarised by the Itami City Library, opened into strips 50 to 100 m wide. On Horikawa, notices went up from 18 March and demolition began around 25 March. After the war about half of the cleared land was bought for roads and parks and the rest was returned; Oike-dori, cleared in the same campaign, was fixed as a 50-meter planning road in 1947.<sup>1920 22</sup>

The 1945-1950 aerial photograph in this dossier shows both outcomes. The roofs of Gion, Miyagawa-cho and the Kiyomizu slopes are dense and whole, and the Kamo's gravel bars and the east-bank line of canal and railway are sharp, but a pale, broken band runs east from Gojo bridge where the houses of Gojo-dori had been pulled down. Today the same line is a multi-lane road; set the two photographs side by side and the scale of the 1945 demolitions is plain.<sup>1923</sup>

## Reading the ground today

Two decisions of 1976 fixed parts of the old landscape. On 1 July that year Kyoto City declared Sannenzaka and Gion Shinbashi historic preservation districts, moving them from a townscape scheme of its own, begun in 1972, into the new national system; Ishibe-koji was added to the Sannenzaka district in 1995. About seven in ten of Shinbashi's roughly 75 buildings are traditional teahouse-style townhouses, some with back rooms over the Shirakawa, and about 65 percent of the buildings in the Sannenzaka district are traditional, from mushiko-style townhouses with low upper floors to Taisho-era houses on Ishibe-koji.<sup>121314</sup>

The railway half of the 1935 plan came true on 24 May 1987, when the Keihan line between Tofukuji and Sanjo went underground. The city built Kawabata-dori on the old track bed, removing eight level crossings that had knotted the traffic on Shijo and Gojo. The broad road on the east bank is therefore the railway's former route, and the deepened channel below it dates from the works of 1936-1947.<sup>910 1718</sup>

Smaller traces reward a closer look. Under Sanjo Ohashi, stone piers said to date from Hideyoshi's bridge stand on concrete footings added when the bed was lowered; under Shijo Ohashi, timber piles from the arched bridge of 1913 still break the surface. Gojo-dori, much wider than the old streets around it, is the firebreak of 1945. And on Shijo-dori east of Yamato-oji the small temple Chugen-ji keeps a Jizo said to have been enshrined after the river commissioner Seta Tamekane checked a flood in 1228: the 'rain-stopping Jizo', whose name drifted over the centuries into the 'eye-disease Jizo'.<sup>510 1119</sup>

## Timeline

|              |                                                                                                                                            |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 824          | The court creates the Bokashi, an office to repair the Kamo embankments. <sup>5</sup>                                                      |
| 869          | Gion goryo-e, the rite against epidemic that became the Gion Festival, according to Yasaka Shrine. <sup>15</sup>                           |
| 1070         | A government decree fixes the Gion shrine's domain between the hills, the Kamo, Sanjo and old Gojo. <sup>15</sup>                          |
| 1590         | Sanjo Ohashi built under Hideyoshi by Mashita Nagamori; in the same Tensho era the Gojo bridge is moved south from Matsubara. <sup>2</sup> |
| 1597         | Mimizuka raised beside the Great Buddha hall of Hokoji. <sup>7</sup>                                                                       |
| 1669-1670    | Kanbun stone embankments built along the Kamo; seven theaters licensed on Shijo (1669). <sup>25</sup>                                      |
| 1712         | Teahouse streets of Gion's 'inner six blocks', today's Shinbashi district, laid out. <sup>12</sup>                                         |
| 1868         | Gion-sha renamed Yasaka Shrine under the separation of Shinto and Buddhism. <sup>315</sup>                                                 |
| 1894         | Kamo canal of the Lake Biwa Canal completed along the east bank. <sup>5</sup>                                                              |
| 1910-1915    | Keihan railway opens to Gojo (1910) and Sanjo (1915) along the east bank. <sup>17</sup>                                                    |
| 29 June 1935 | Record rain floods the Kamo; Sanjo and Gojo bridges are washed away. River works follow, 1936-1947. <sup>19</sup>                          |
| 1945         | 16 January: Umamachi air raid. March-April: houses along Gojo, Horikawa and Oike demolished for firebreaks. <sup>1921</sup>                |
| 1976         | Sannenzaka and Gion Shinbashi become historic preservation districts (1 July). <sup>1213</sup>                                             |
| 1987         | Keihan line put underground between Tofukuji and Sanjo; Kawabata-dori built on the track bed. <sup>1718</sup>                              |

## Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1

**Sanjo Ohashi** 三条大橋. From the riverbank path, look at the piers: stone columns said to survive from Hideyoshi's bridge of 1590 now stand on concrete footings, added when the riverbed was lowered by about 2 m after the 1935 flood. The bronze finials (giboshi) on the railings were already treasured in 1915 as relics of that bridge.<sup>21011</sup> [map](#)
- 2

**Shijo Ohashi, Minamiza and Chugen-ji** 四条大橋・南座・仲源寺（目疾地藏）. Under the bridge, look for the timber piles of the 1913 arch bridge; at its east end stands the Minamiza, the last of the Shijo theaters licensed in 1669. A short walk east along Shijo-dori, past Yamato-oji, Chugen-ji keeps the flood-stopping Jizo of 1228.<sup>24510</sup> [map](#)
- 3

**Gion Shinbashi and the Shirakawa** 祇園新橋・白川. The teahouse street of 1712, where two-storey teahouses show their rear side along the Shirakawa; the stone paving and trees of Shirakawa-dori are protected with the buildings.<sup>12</sup> [map](#)
- 4

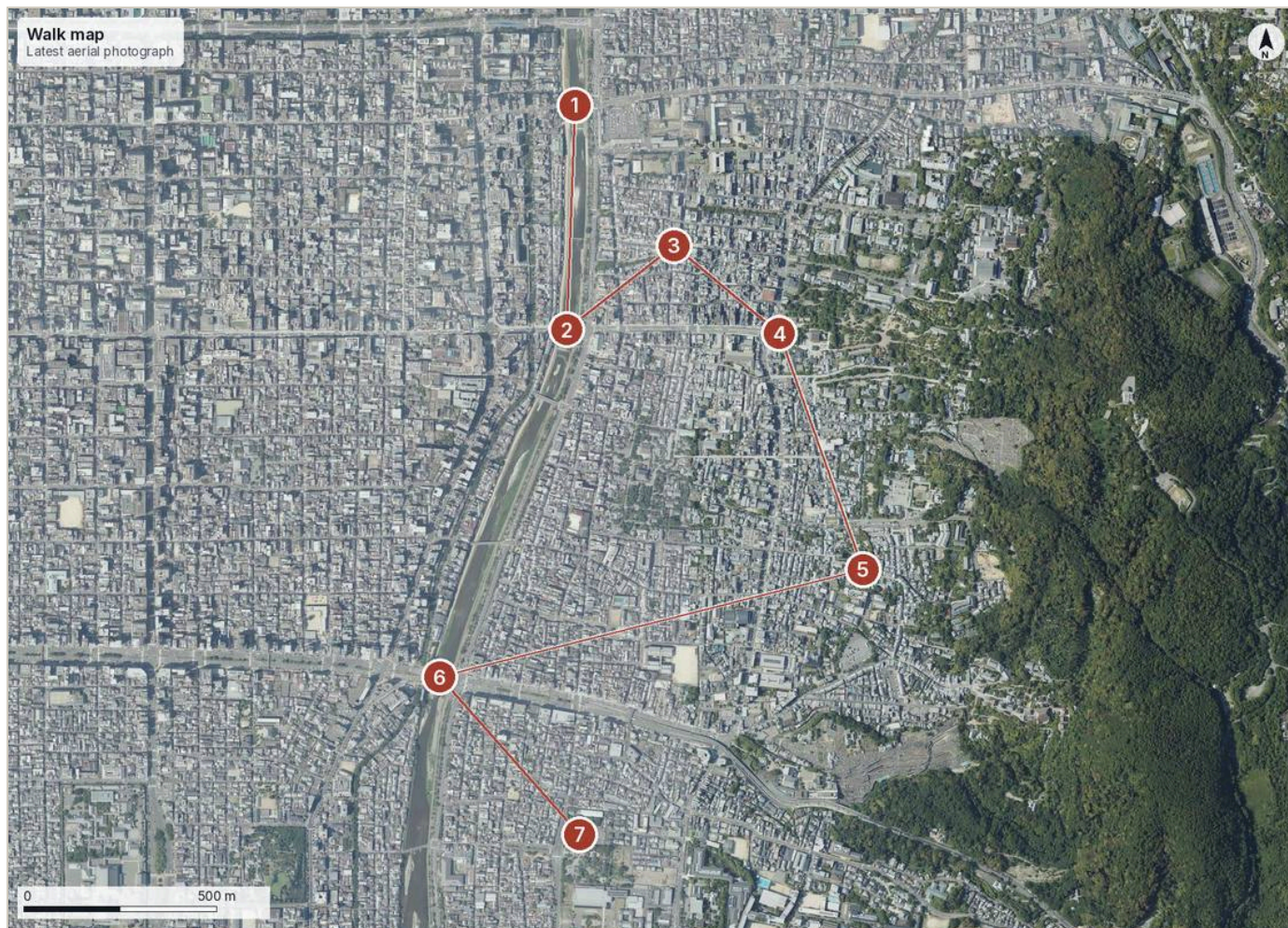
**Yasaka Shrine, west gate** 八坂神社 西楼門. The west gate closes the eastern end of Shijo-dori. Just inside it, on the left, find the old name Kanshin-in cut into the stone water basin, a survivor of the renaming of 1868.<sup>15</sup> [map](#)
- 5

**Sannenzaka and Ninenzaka to Kiyomizu-dera** 産寧坂・二年坂・清水寺. Stone steps and bent lanes of the 1976 preservation district lead past the Yasaka pagoda to the temple of 778 and its stage over the slope.<sup>1316</sup> [map](#)
- 6

**Gojo-zaka down to Gojo Ohashi** 五条坂・五条大橋. Pottery shops recall the Kiyomizu-ware trade described in 1928. Walking down to the river, note the breadth of Gojo-dori: the firebreak of spring 1945. The bridge itself stands on the line to which Hideyoshi moved it.<sup>2419</sup> [map](#)
- 7

**Hokoji bell and Mimizuka** 方広寺・耳塚. South of Gojo, the stone walls of the Great Buddha precinct run beside the National Museum; the bell of 1614 hangs at Hokoji, and west of Toyokuni Shrine the mound of Mimizuka, topped by a stone stupa, marks where the trophies taken in the invasions of Korea were buried.<sup>7</sup> [map](#)

## Walk map



The walking stops, numbered as in the notes, on the latest GSI aerial photograph (3.3 × 2.4 km, north up). Lines join the stops in order and are not a route; follow streets on the ground. Each stop in the notes links to a map app.

- |   |                                                                 |   |                                                                      |
|---|-----------------------------------------------------------------|---|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>Sanjo Ohashi</b> <a href="#">map</a>                         | 5 | <b>Sannenzaka and Ninenzaka to Kiyomizu-dera</b> <a href="#">map</a> |
| 2 | <b>Shijo Ohashi, Minamiza and Chugen-ji</b> <a href="#">map</a> | 6 | <b>Gojo-zaka down to Gojo Ohashi</b> <a href="#">map</a>             |
| 3 | <b>Gion Shinbashi and the Shirakawa</b> <a href="#">map</a>     | 7 | <b>Hokoji bell and Mimizuka</b> <a href="#">map</a>                  |
| 4 | <b>Yasaka Shrine, west gate</b> <a href="#">map</a>             |   |                                                                      |

## The stops today

Recent photographs of the stops, numbered as in the walking notes. Each was checked against the place the note describes; the line under the name says what it shows.



### 1. Sanjo Ohashi

Sanjo Ohashi and its piers over the Kamo River, seen from the east end

"Sanjo-Ohashi Bridge from east" by そらみみ, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons



### 2. Shijo Ohashi, Minamiza and Chugen-ji

The facade of the Minamiza theatre

"Minami-za Theatre, Kyoto (Jan 2020)" by Chainwit, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons



### 3. Gion Shinbashi and the Shirakawa

The Shirakawa canal in Gion, with the rear of teahouses along its bank

"Shirakara Canal, Gion, Kyoto" by MichaelMaggs, CC BY-SA 2.5, via Wikimedia Commons



### 4. Yasaka Shrine, west gate

The vermilion west gate (Nishi-romon) of Yasaka Shrine

"20131014 02 Kyoto - Higashiyama - Yasaka Shrine (10512529846)" by Sjaak Kempe from Groningen, The Netherlands, CC BY 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons



### 5. Sannenzaka and Ninenzaka to Kiyomizu-dera

The stone-paved Ninenzaka lane in the early morning

"Pedestrian road with pavements and paper umbrellas, Higashiyama-ku, Kyoto, Japan, early morning" by Basile Morin, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons



### 6. Gojo-zaka down to Gojo Ohashi

Gojo Ohashi across the Kamo River, seen from the riverbank

"五条大橋" by KeraKera55, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons



## 7. Hokoji bell and Mimizuka

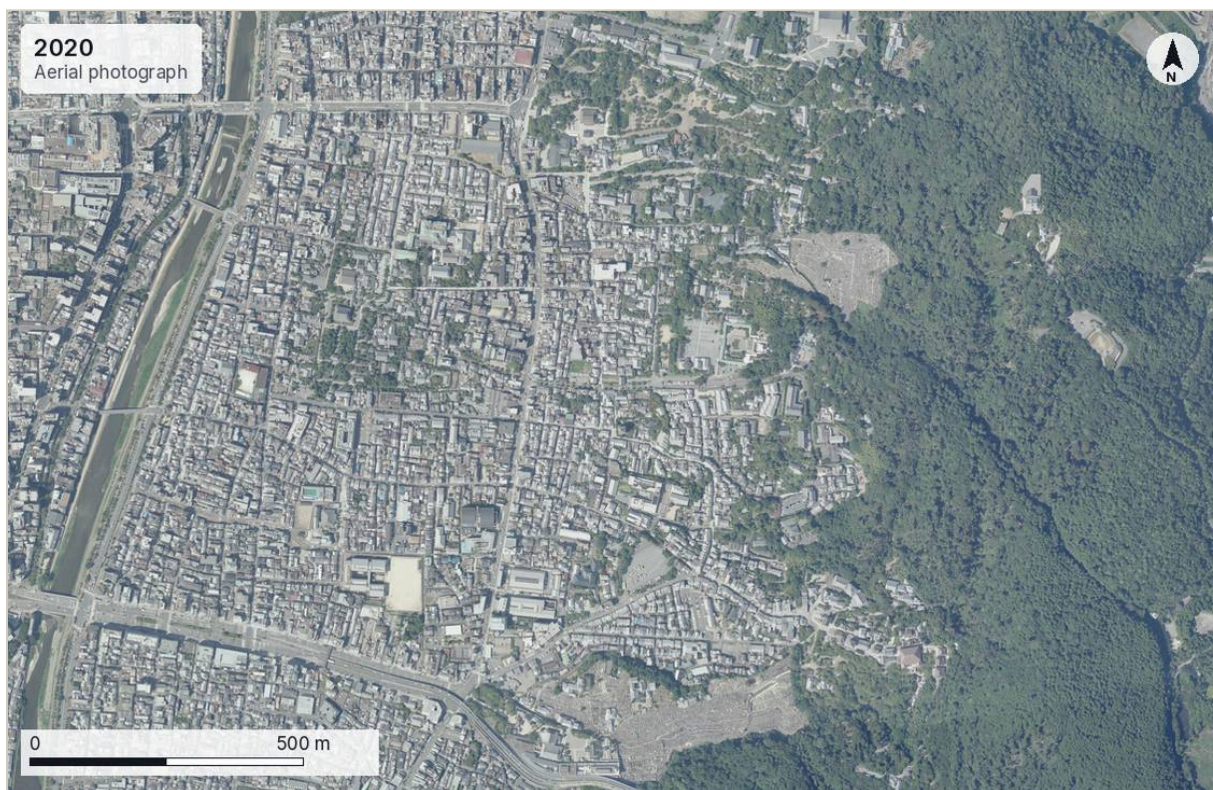
The Mimizuka mound topped by a stone stupa

"Mimizuka2" by KENPEI, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons

## The same ground, 1945–1950 and 2020



1945–1950 aerial photograph (US military photography) — GSI Tiles *ort\_USA10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2020 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2020*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

**How to compare.** Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

## The decades in between

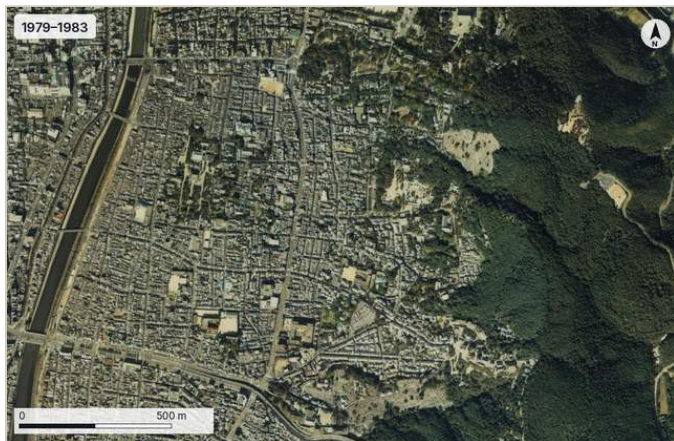
Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1961–1969 · GSI Tiles *ort\_old10*, processed

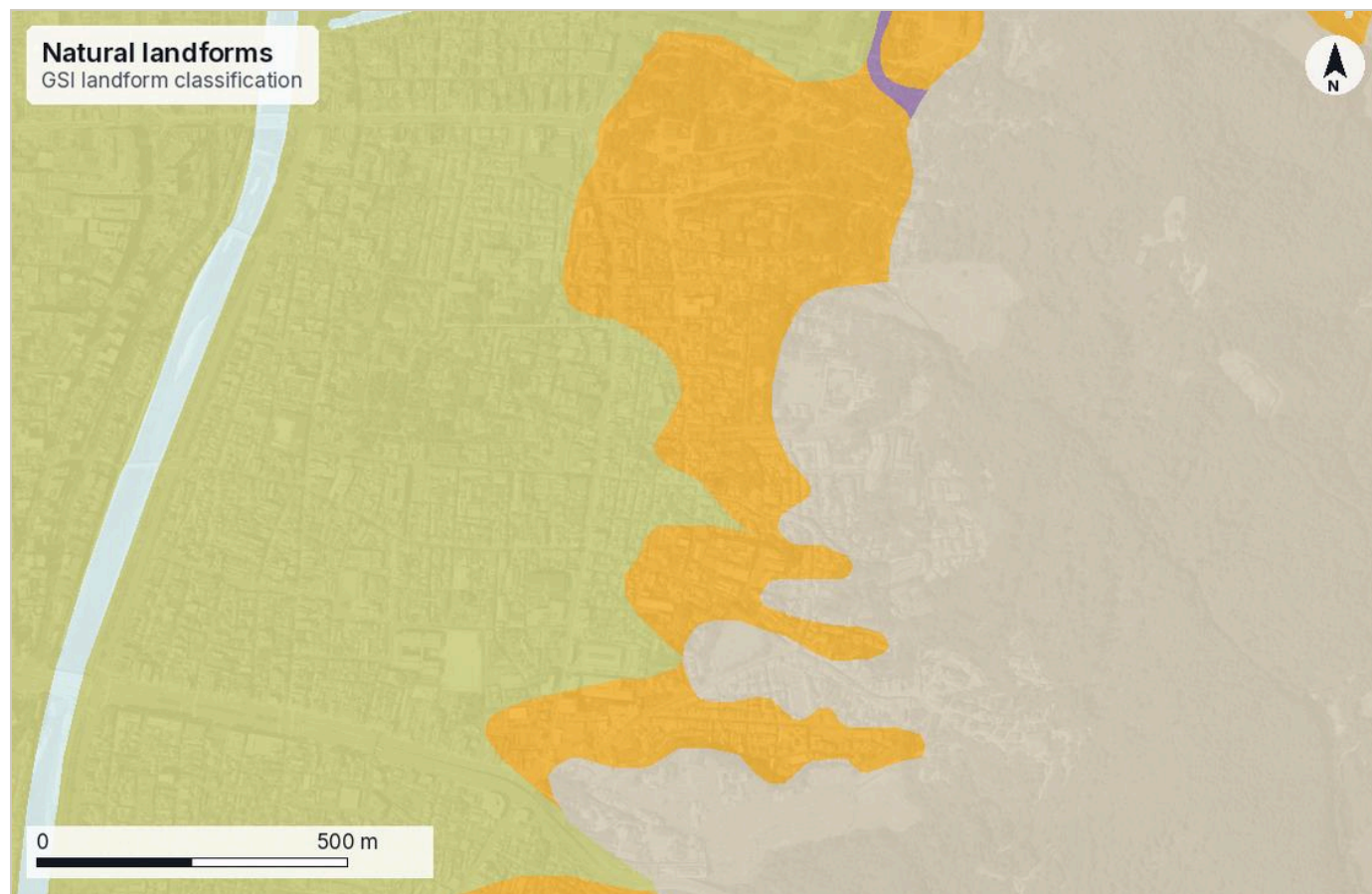


1974–1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed



1979–1983 · GSI Tiles *gazo2*, processed

## Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.



### What the main landforms mean

**Alluvial fan (42%).** Gently sloping ground spreading fan-like from a valley mouth, built from sediment dropped by floods. Floodwater from the mountains, and debris flows near the valley mouth. Relatively firm ground; a slight liquefaction tendency on the lower fan.

**Mountain and hill slopes (42%).** Ridges, valleys and fairly steep ground, including terrace-scarp slopes and volcanic ground. Heavy rain or earthquakes can trigger slope failures, debris flows and landslides.

**Plateaus and terraces (13%).** Flat ground standing in steps above its surroundings, left behind as the land around it was eroded. River flooding is rarely a threat unless the terrace is only slightly above the river; watch the slopes at its edges. Firm ground: shaking is relatively weak and liquefaction is unlikely.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

## Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI “Meiji-era lowland” data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s–1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

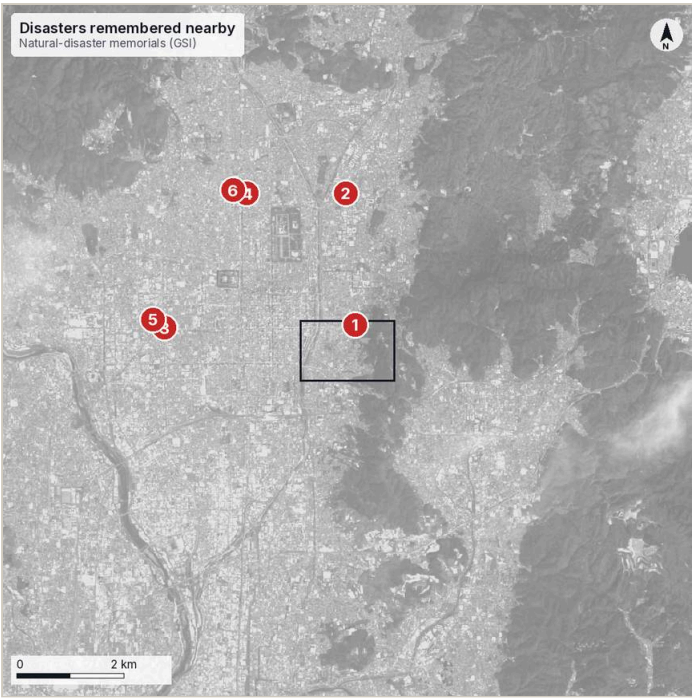
### Man-made ground

No man-made ground mapped in this frame.

### Meiji-era lowland

- Sand and gravel 2.0%
- River, pond or sea 1.6%

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 16 km across.

Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 8 km are listed.

| Memorial                                                                                    | Disaster                             | Erected | Distance |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|---------|----------|
| 1 Statue of the bond between teachers and pupils, for the 1934 Muroto Typhoon victims 師弟愛の像 | Muroto Typhoon (21 Sep 1934) · other | 1960    | 0.6 km   |
| 2 Stone record of the 1934 Muroto Typhoon damage at Yosei school 記念誌                        | Muroto Typhoon (21 Sep 1934) · other | 1941    | 3.7 km   |
| 3 Memorial tower for the Junna school victims of the 1934 Muroto Typhoon 風災慰霊塔              | Muroto Typhoon (21 Sep 1934) · other | 1935    | 4.3 km   |
| 4 Memorial stone recording the 1935 flood inundation 昭和十年水害浸水被害記念碑                          | Kyoto flood (29 Jun 1935) · flood    | unknown | 4.3 km   |
| 5 Memorial to the 1934 Muroto Typhoon disaster at Junna school 風災記念碑                        | Muroto Typhoon (21 Sep 1934) · other | unknown | 4.6 km   |
| 6 Memorial to the 41 pupils of Nishijin school killed by the 1934 Muroto Typhoon 風害記念碑      | Muroto Typhoon (21 Sep 1934) · other | 1935    | 4.6 km   |

What the memorials record

1. **Statue of the bond between teachers and pupils, for the 1934 Muroto Typhoon victims.** On 21 September 1934 the winds of the Muroto Typhoon, which raged across western Japan, brought down wooden buildings at several schools in and around Kyoto, killing 162 children and 4 teachers trapped beneath them. The present statue was rebuilt after the war.
2. **Stone record of the 1934 Muroto Typhoon damage at Yosei school.** When the Muroto Typhoon struck the Kinki region on 21 September 1934, Yosei Elementary School recorded 3 wooden classrooms destroyed, 3 half-destroyed, 4 tilted and 15 needing repair, and the roof of its indoor gymnasium badly damaged. None of the children was hurt.
3. **Memorial tower for the Junna school victims of the 1934 Muroto Typhoon.** On 21 September 1934 the winds of the Muroto Typhoon trapped more than 200 people under the collapsed building of Junna Elementary School (now Saiin Elementary School). Erected on the first anniversary, the tower bears the names of the 32 children and the teacher, Matsuura, who died.
4. **Memorial stone recording the 1935 flood inundation.** Before dawn on 29 June 1935, after days of heavy rain, all the rivers in Kyoto overflowed and more than 40,000 houses in the city were flooded. In the Ogawa district the Kamidachiuri-Ogawa stone bridge fell at 5 am, and houses along the stream collapsed, were swept away or were half-destroyed. The inscription records water four shaku (about 1.2 m) deep.

**5. Memorial to the 1934 Muroto Typhoon disaster at Junna school.** On 21 September 1934 the winds of the Muroto Typhoon, which raged across western Japan, trapped more than 200 people under the collapsed building of Junna Elementary School (now Saiin Elementary School); 32 children and a teacher, Matsuura, were killed.

**6. Memorial to the 41 pupils of Nishijin school killed by the 1934 Muroto Typhoon.** On 21 September 1934 the winds of the Muroto Typhoon, which raged across western Japan, brought down a building of Nishijin Elementary School, and 41 children trapped beneath it died.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

## Sources

1. 京都府 (Kyoto Prefecture), 昭和十年六月二十九日鴨川未曾有の大洪水と旧都復興計画 [The unprecedented Kamo River flood of 29 June 1935 and a plan to rebuild the old capital], 1935; NDL frames 16, 17, 18, 19, 22, 23, 24. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1454796/1/16> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Rainfall, flood levels at Shijo and Pontocho, the fight for the Kamo embankment, bridge losses, the 1935 improvement plan (70 m channel, 650 m<sup>3</sup>/s, Keihan underground).
2. 京都府 (Kyoto Prefecture), 京都府誌 下 [Gazetteer of Kyoto Prefecture, vol. 2], 1915; NDL frames 157, 158, 160, 171, 273, 275, 276. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1229671/1/158> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Sanjo, Shijo and Gojo bridges; the 1915 view of the Kamo; Gion teahouse licenses (1732); Miyako Odori; the seven Shijo theaters (1669).
3. 京都府 (Kyoto Prefecture), 京都府誌 上 [Gazetteer of Kyoto Prefecture, vol. 1], 1915; NDL frame 132. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1229654/1/132> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Yasaka Shrine entry: former names, 1868 renaming, Gion goryo-e.
4. 京都市 (Kyoto City), 京都名勝誌 [Famous places of Kyoto (city guide)], 1928; NDL frames 143, 144, 145, 146, 150, 154, 159. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1907825/1/145> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Minamiza and the Shijo theaters (Okuni beside the Gion shrine's south gate); growth of Gion Shinchi from a poor hamlet; Miyako Odori (1872-73); Rokuhara; Sannenzaka name; Gojo-zaka potteries.
5. フィールド・ミュージアム京都 都市史08 鴨川 [Field Museum Kyoto, urban history 08: the Kamo River], 京都市歴史資料館 (Kyoto City Historical Archives). <https://www2.city.kyoto.lg.jp/somu/rekishi/fm/nenpyou/htmlsheet/toshi08.html>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Course of the Kamo; Shirakawa's lament; Bokashi (824); 1017 flood; Kanbun embankment (1669-70); Kamo canal (1894); Mehyami Jizo.
6. フィールド・ミュージアム京都 都市史09 六波羅 [Field Museum Kyoto, urban history 09: Rokuhara], 京都市歴史資料館 (Kyoto City Historical Archives). <https://www2.city.kyoto.lg.jp/somu/rekishi/fm/nenpyou/htmlsheet/toshi09.html>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Rokuhara as the entrance to Toribenno; Rokuharamitsuji (963); Taira mansions; the pilgrim road to Kiyomizu.
7. フィールド・ミュージアム京都 都市史19 大仏殿 [Field Museum Kyoto, urban history 19: the Great Buddha Hall], 京都市歴史資料館 (Kyoto City Historical Archives). <https://www2.city.kyoto.lg.jp/somu/rekishi/fm/nenpyou/htmlsheet/toshi19.html>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Hokoji Great Buddha hall; stone walls by the National Museum; the 1614 bell; Mimizuka (1597).
8. フィールド・ミュージアム京都 都市史22 高瀬川 [Field Museum Kyoto, urban history 22: the Takase River], 京都市歴史資料館 (Kyoto City Historical Archives). <https://www2.city.kyoto.lg.jp/somu/rekishi/fm/nenpyou/htmlsheet/toshi22.html>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Takase canal opened 1614, its boats, closure in 1920.
9. 昭和10年の鴨川大洪水とその後の治水対策について [The great Kamo flood of 1935 and flood control since], 京都府 建設交通部河川課 (Kyoto Prefecture, River Division). <https://www.pref.kyoto.jp/kasen/1172825060356.html>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Official 1935 damage figures; river works 1936-1947; performance in the August 1959 flood.
10. 鴨川真発見記 第256号 (平成28年12月) [Kamo River notes no. 256 (December 2016)], 京都府 京都土木事務所 (Kyoto Prefecture, Kyoto Civil Engineering Office). <https://www.pref.kyoto.jp/shinhakken/2812.html>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Riverbed lowered about 2 m after 1935, visible at Sanjo Ohashi; traces of the arch bridge under Shijo Ohashi.
11. 鴨川真発見記 第125号 (平成26年1月) [Kamo River notes no. 125 (January 2014)], 京都府 京都土木事務所 (Kyoto Prefecture, Kyoto Civil Engineering Office). <https://www.pref.kyoto.jp/shinhakken/2601.html>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Sanjo Ohashi finials and stone piers; damage to Sanjo bridge and the Keihan terminus in 1935.
12. 祇園新橋伝統的建造物群保存地区保存計画 [Preservation plan, Gion Shinbashi historic district], 京都市 (Kyoto City). <https://www.city.kyoto.lg.jp/tokei/page/0000281763.html>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Origins of the district (1712); link to the Kamo embankment; building types; designation 1 July 1976.
13. 産寧坂伝統的建造物群保存地区保存計画 [Preservation plan, Sannenzaka historic district], 京都市 (Kyoto City). <https://www.city.kyoto.lg.jp/tokei/page/0000281761.html>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Gate-town origins; mid-Edo streets; Ishibe-koji; traditional buildings about 65 percent; designation 1 July 1976.
14. 伝統的建造物群保存地区 [Historic preservation districts of Kyoto], 京都市 (Kyoto City). <https://www.city.kyoto.lg.jp/tokei/page/0000281305.html>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: 1972 townscape ordinance; 1976 designation of Sannenzaka and Gion Shinbashi; 1995 extension to Ishibe-koji.
15. 八坂神社の歴史／八坂神社の建造物／祇園祭 [Yasaka Shrine: history, buildings, Gion Festival], 八坂神社 (Yasaka Shrine). <https://www.yasaka-jinja.or.jp/about/history/>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Founding traditions (656, 876); 1070 decree on the precinct; festival origin 869; names before 1868; main hall 1654, National Treasure 2020. Also /about/architecture/ and /event/gion/.
16. 清水寺の歴史 [History of Kiyomizu-dera], 羽羽山 清水寺 (Kiyomizu-dera). <https://www.kiyomizudera.or.jp/history.php>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Founding (778); rebuilding in 1633; the stage; World Heritage listing (1994).
17. 沿革 略年史 [Company chronology], 京阪電気鉄道 (Keihan Electric Railway). <https://www.keihan.co.jp/corporate/company/history.html>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Opening to Gojo (1910) and Sanjo (1915); undergrounding Tofukuji-Sanjo (24 May 1987).
18. 京阪関連事業 [Keihan-related projects (Keihan main line undergrounding)], 京都市 建設局 (Kyoto City Construction Bureau). <https://www.city.kyoto.lg.jp/kensetu/page/0000040339.html>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Undergrounding Sanjo-Tofukuji (2.8 km, 8 level crossings removed); Kawabata-dori built on the old track bed.

19. レファレンス協同データベース：「戦時中、京都で周辺の民家を壊して五条通を拡張した」という話をきいた [Collaborative Reference Database answer on the wartime widening of Gojo-dori], 伊丹市立図書館 (Itami City Library), via NDL.  
[https://crd.ndl.go.jp/reference/detail?page=ref\\_view&id=1000244002](https://crd.ndl.go.jp/reference/detail?page=ref_view&id=1000244002), checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Four rounds of building clearance in Kyoto; the third round (March–April 1945) with its extent, as summarised from 京都地図絵巻 (2007) p.71.
20. レファレンス協同データベース：堀川通の建物疎開が始まった時期を知りたい [Collaborative Reference Database answer on when the Horikawa clearance began], 京都府立京都学・歴史館 (Kyoto Prefectural Library and Archives), via NDL.  
[https://crd.ndl.go.jp/reference/detail?page=ref\\_view&id=1000087836](https://crd.ndl.go.jp/reference/detail?page=ref_view&id=1000087836), checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Horikawa and Gojo clearances from March 1945; notice and demolition dates; Kawaguchi Tomoko's 2014 study of the 'non-war-damaged city'.
21. 資料ガイドNo.61 吉井勇日記にみる馬町空襲 [Guide no. 61: the Umamachi air raid in Yoshii Isamu's diary], 京都府立京都学・歴史館 (Kyoto Prefectural Library and Archives), 2019. <https://www.pref.kyoto.jp/rekisaikan/documents/shiryoguide061.pdf>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: The raid of 16 January 1945 on Umamachi; more than thirty dead; Yoshii's diary entries.
22. 御池通の概要 [Outline of Oike-dori], 京都市 都市計画局 (Kyoto City Urban Planning Bureau).  
<https://www.city.kyoto.lg.jp/tokei/page/0000004448.html>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: 1945 clearance of Oike-dori and its 1947 designation as a 50 m planning road.
23. 地理院タイル 空中写真 (1945~1950年/米軍撮影) および全国最新写真 (シームレス) [GSI Tiles: aerial photographs 1945-1950 (US forces) and current seamless photographs], 国土地理院 (Geospatial Information Authority of Japan).  
<https://maps.gsi.go.jp/development/ichiran.html>, checked 2026-09-27. Used for: Visual comparison of Gojo-dori, the Kamo east bank and Gion (layers ort\_USA10 and seamlessphoto, zoom 16).

## Further reading

- 京都の歴史9 世界の京都 (京都市編, 1976) — Kyoto City's official history for the 1920s-1960s; full-text search hits on 疎開 (clearance) at frames 21, 29, 31 and 60; a library reference answer cites p.7 for the building clearances.  
<https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/2991102> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 史料京都の歴史10 東山区 (京都市編, 1987) — Documents and commentary for Higashiyama ward, block by block; full-text hits on 寛文 at frames 30-40. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/9576297> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- かくされていた空襲：京都空襲の体験と記録 (京都空襲を記録する会・京都府立総合資料館編, 1974) — Survivor accounts and records of the Kyoto raids; full-text hits on 馬町 (Umamachi) at frames 83, 87 and 91-94. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/12399030> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 建設行政のあゆみ：京都市建設局小史 (1983) — Kyoto City's own account of road and river works; full-text hits on 五条通 at frames 20-22 and 41-43. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/9671879> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 京都町名ものがたり (川嶋将生・鎌田道隆, 1979) — Street and block names explained; the Kanbun embankment is discussed at frames 86-87. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/9574405> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 近世都市・京都 (鎌田道隆, 1976) — Early-modern urban growth of Kyoto; the Kanbun embankment at frames 79-80. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/9573117> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 京都空襲 (久津間保治, 語り伝える京都の戦争2, 1996) — Detailed account of the Kyoto raids including Umamachi (hits at frames 32-38); NDL premises only. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/13977274> (NDL premises only)
- 鴨川水害史(1) (京都大学防災研究所年報26 B-2, 1983) — Research history of Kamo floods by the Disaster Prevention Research Institute; open online but not used as a source here. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/9383917> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))

## Where a Deep Research request would go next

- **Street-level records of the 1945 building clearances (which houses on Gojo-dori were taken, compensation, return of land)** — Kyoto City Historical Archives (京都市歴史資料館), including 『京都市政史編さん通信』 no. 12, 'On the building clearances in Kyoto City'; Kawaguchi Tomoko, 『建物疎開と都市防空』 (2014), table 4-3; 『醒泉学区強制疎開の記録』 (1987). Consult in the Archives' reading room or through the Kyoto Prefectural Library and Archives, which holds all three; ask for the clearance maps by school district.
- **Photographs and administrative files of the 1935 flood and the 1936-1947 Kamo works** — Kyoto Prefectural Library and Archives (京都学・歴史館): prefectural administrative records, Kurokawa Suizan photographs; Kyoto Prefecture Kyoto Civil Engineering Office photo records. Search the Rekisaikan catalogue for 鴨川 改修 and 行政文書; request viewing in advance.
- **The Umamachi raid of 16 January 1945 from the American side** — US National Archives (NARA): 20th Air Force and XXI Bomber Command mission records (RG 18) and US Strategic Bombing Survey files (RG 243). Search the NARA catalog by date; records are open and can be ordered as reproductions.
- **House-by-house history of a Gion or Sannenzaka property** — Kyoto District Legal Affairs Bureau (closed land registers and cadastral maps) and the preservation-district surveys held by Kyoto City's townscape section. Request old land registers (旧土地台帳) by lot number; the townscape section can advise on survey reports for designated districts.
- **Medieval Gion-sha records behind the 1070 decree and the festival** — 『八坂神社記録』 (1923) and 『八坂神社文書』, published by the shrine; the 1923 edition is open in the NDL Digital Collections. Read online (NDL) or ask Yasaka Shrine's office about access to originals.

## Caveats

- Sources date the Kanbun embankment slightly differently: Kyoto City's historical archives give 1669–1670 for stone banks on both sides, while a Kyoto Prefecture column gives 1668 for the right bank between Imadegawa and Gojo.
- Founding dates for Yasaka Shrine (656 or 876) and Kiyomizu-dera (778) are institutional traditions, reported here as such. The 1915 prefectural gazetteer gives 869 for the shrine's founding and 876 for the first goryo-e, the reverse of the shrine's own account followed here.
- Casualty figures for the 1935 flood and the Umamachi raid differ between sources; this dossier gives Kyoto Prefecture's current flood figures and the Prefectural Library's 'more than thirty' for Umamachi.
- The observations on the 1945–1950 photograph were made on the GSI tiles at zoom 16; features smaller than a house plot cannot be read reliably at that scale.

Digitised books are cited, not reproduced: the page frames let you open the same page in the NDL Digital Collections. Aerial photographs, landform and memorial data: GSI, processed by Japan Time Atlas. Positions of the walking stops: © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL), found with Nominatim. Photographs of the stops: Wikimedia Commons contributors, under the licences named beside each; scaled, not otherwise altered. This experimental edition was checked against its cited sources on 2026-09-28 but has not had independent fact-checking.